
Payments Agent Ecosystem Handbook

10 specialized AI agents working together to monitor, optimize, and protect a multi-PSP payments platform. Architecture reference, agent specifications, cross-agent correlation patterns, and real-world scenarios.

Agent	Layer	Schedule
Incident Agent	Real-Time Detection	Always on
KPI Monitor	Real-Time Detection	Hourly sweeps
Fraud Analyst	Real-Time Detection	Hourly + triggered
Cost Optimizer	Optimization & Analysis	Daily
Checkout Optimizer	Optimization & Analysis	Daily
Security Audit	Optimization & Analysis	Weekly + on integration
Reconciliation	Compliance & Relationships	Daily / weekly / monthly
Partner Health	Compliance & Relationships	Weekly + before renewals
Regulatory Monitor	Compliance & Relationships	Weekly scans
Synthesis Agent	Synthesis Layer	Daily 08:00 + weekly Monday

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1. Architecture Overview

The payments agent ecosystem consists of 10 specialized agents organized in four layers. Each agent owns a specific domain and produces structured JSON output. The Synthesis Agent sits on top, reading all outputs and producing the daily briefing.

Layer	Agents	Purpose
Real-Time Detection	Incident Agent, KPI Monitor, Fraud Analyst	Continuous monitoring of transaction health, outage detection, fraud
Optimization & Analysis	Cost Optimizer, Checkout Optimizer, Security Finding	Find money on the table, pre-submit funnel analysis, security post
Compliance & Relationships	Reconciliation, Partner Health, Regulatory Monitor	Settlement verification, vendor SLA tracking, regulatory compliance
Synthesis	Synthesis Agent	Editorial layer — correlates signals, prioritizes findings, produces brief

The key design principle: agents produce structured data, they don't make decisions for other agents. The Incident Agent doesn't tell the Cost Optimizer to reroute — it recommends a routing shift and the Cost Optimizer validates capacity. The Synthesis Agent doesn't override findings — it merges correlated signals into single narratives so the head of payments sees one story, not four alerts.

Every agent follows the same output contract: structured JSON with severity, confidence, dollar impact, hypothesis, and recommended action. This contract makes synthesis possible — the editorial layer can score and sort findings from any agent using the same formula.

2. Agent Specifications

Incident Agent

Real-Time Detection | Schedule: Always on | ID: payments-incident-agent

Real-time payments incident detection and triage for multi-PSP stacks.

Core principle: Every alert must include a hypothesis and a suggested action. A number without a diagnosis is not an alert — it's a data point.

What it does

- Monitors real-time transaction streams for anomalies requiring immediate human attention
- Runs a mandatory triage protocol before every alert: checks PSP status pages, recent deploys, and blast radius
- Classifies incidents by severity: P0 (critical, @here), P1 (alert, no @here), P2 (monitor), P3 (log for briefing)
- Recommends routing changes when a PSP is degraded and an alternative has capacity
- Never alerts on a single data point — requires sustained confirmation

Key metrics & thresholds

- Success rate threshold: <95% sustained 5+ min = P0
- Auth rate drop >1% sustained 10+ min = P1
- Latency p99 >3s sustained 15+ min = P3

Triage protocol

1. Is this a known PSP incident? Check status pages. If confirmed, downgrade urgency.
2. Is there a recent deploy? Check deploy log for last 2 hours. Correlation ≠ causation.
3. What is the blast radius? Narrow (one BIN range) vs broad (all PSPs, all markets).

Signal flow

Direction	Connected agents
Sends to	KPI Monitor, Cost Optimizer, Partner Health, Synthesis
Receives from	KPI Monitor, PSP status pages
Slack channels	#payments-incidents (P0 with @here), #payments-alerts (P1)

Failure modes to avoid

- Alerting on a single spike without sustained confirmation
- Recommending routing shift when the issue is in your own infrastructure
- Missing a broad outage because the first signal was in a narrow segment

KPI Monitor

Real-Time Detection | Schedule: Hourly sweeps | ID: payments-kpi-monitor

Monitors core payments health metrics across a multi-PSP payments stack.

Core principle: Detect meaningful deviations with enough context that a head of payments can act immediately — not just know that something changed.

What it does

- Tracks Tier 1 metrics daily: success rate, authorization rate, latency p95/p99, system uptime
- Tier 2 weekly: chargeback rate, false positive rate, checkout conversion by method, refund rate
- Tier 3 monthly: cost per transaction, payment method mix shift, PSP routing efficiency by BIN
- Always segments by PSP, payment method, geography, card type — never reports blended totals alone
- Classifies declines: issuer, technical, fraud blocks, 3DS failures

Key metrics & thresholds

- Success rate alert: >0.5% drop sustained >15 min
- Auth rate alert: >1% drop sustained >10 min
- Latency alert: p99 >3s sustained >15 min
- Uptime target: >99.99%

Triage protocol

- Compare against rolling 28-day baseline segmented by hour-of-day and day-of-week
- Deviation must be >2 standard deviations from same time-slot baseline
- Must be sustained for at least 15 minutes
- Must be concentrated in a specific segment — identify which one before surfacing

Signal flow

Direction	Connected agents
Sends to	Incident Agent, Fraud Analyst, Synthesis
Receives from	Fraud Analyst, Incident Agent
Slack channels	#payments-incidents (P0/P1), #payments-alerts (P2), #payments-briefing (daily)

Failure modes to avoid

- Comparing Saturday night to Monday morning (always use same time-slot baseline)
- Alerting on p50 latency (only p95 and p99 matter)
- Surfacing a blended metric without segmentation
- Alerting during known maintenance windows

Fraud Analyst

Real-Time Detection | Schedule: Hourly + triggered | ID: payments-fraud-analyst

Analyzes fraud signals, false positive rates, chargeback patterns, and fraud model health.

Core principle: Always report fraud rate and false positive rate together — never one without the other. A fraud team that achieves 3 bps fraud by blocking 8% of good customers has made the company worse off.

What it does

- Holds two opposing objectives: minimize fraud losses AND minimize false declines
- Detects model drift when score distributions shift without corresponding fraud outcome changes
- Classifies chargebacks: unauthorized, friendly fraud, product/service dispute, processing error
- Monitors 3DS challenge rates — above 8% suggests overtriggering
- Calculates false positives by joining blocked transactions against user database

Key metrics & thresholds

- Fraud rate in basis points (fraud losses / GMV x 10,000)
- False positive rate (blocked legitimate transactions)
- Chargeback rate target: <0.1% (Visa/MC monitoring threshold)
- 3DS challenge rate threshold: 8%

Triage protocol

- Calibration check: fraud up + FP flat = too loose; fraud flat + FP up = too tight
- Both rising = new fraud pattern AND model overcorrection — separate problems
- Both falling = healthy improvement

Signal flow

Direction	Connected agents
Sends to	KPI Monitor, Checkout Optimizer, Synthesis
Receives from	KPI Monitor, Checkout Optimizer
Slack channels	#payments-alerts (FP spike, drift, chargeback threshold)

Failure modes to avoid

- Reporting fraud rate without false positive rate
- Conflating friendly fraud with unauthorized fraud (different problems, different fixes)
- Recommending model tightening when the real issue is a new legitimate user behavior pattern

Cost Optimizer

Optimization & Analysis | Schedule: Daily | ID: payments-cost-optimizer

Finds revenue and margin opportunities in multi-PSP payment routing and processing economics.

Core principle: Every finding must answer: 'So what does this cost us?' If you cannot attach a dollar figure, hold it. Minimum threshold: \$10,000/month.

What it does

- Compares net yield ($\text{auth_rate} \times (1 - \text{fee_rate})$) per transaction segment across all PSPs
- Identifies network token adoption gaps — network tokens improve auth rate 1-3% vs processor tokens
- Tracks payment method mix shifts (wallets cost 20-40 bps less than cards)
- Builds rolling PSP scorecards by BIN range, latency, uptime, dispute handling
- Prepares contract negotiation leverage by calculating shiftable volume

Key metrics & thresholds

- Routing gain = $\text{volume_on_suboptimal_psp} \times (\text{best_auth_rate} - \text{current_auth_rate}) \times \text{AOV}$
- Token gap revenue = $(\text{eligible} - \text{tokenized}) \times \text{auth_rate_delta} \times \text{AOV}$
- Mix saving = $\text{volume} \times (\text{current_card_share} - \text{target}) \times (\text{card_fee} - \text{wallet_fee})$
- Auth rate differential threshold: >0.3% to flag routing change

Signal flow

Direction	Connected agents
Sends to	Incident Agent, Partner Health, Synthesis
Receives from	KPI Monitor, Partner Health
Slack channels	#payments-optimisation

Failure modes to avoid

- Routing to lowest fee PSP without considering auth rate (cheaper PSP with 2% lower auth rate is more expensive)
- Recommending routing changes that drop below 2 active PSPs
- Surfacing qualitative observations without dollar amounts

Checkout Optimizer

Optimization & Analysis | Schedule: Daily | ID: payments-checkout-optimizer

Analyzes checkout funnel performance and pre-submission drop-off that PSP data cannot see.

Core principle: A 98.5% payment success rate is meaningless if 15% of users who reach the payment page never submit. PSP data starts at submission. You start earlier.

What it does

- Owns the funnel between payment page load and submit button press
- Tracks 5 funnel stages: page load → method display → method selection → details entry → submit
- Identifies payment method coverage gaps by market (PIX in Brazil, UPI in India, iDEAL in NL, etc.)
- Correlates checkout latency with abandonment (each extra second costs 1-2% conversion)
- Monitors 3DS abandonment and A/B experiment signals

Key metrics & thresholds

- Effective conversion rate = $\text{submit_rate} \times \text{success_rate}$ (true end-to-end)
- Reported success rate = PSP success rate (starts at submit)
- Conversion gap = difference between effective and reported
- Coverage gap impact = $\text{market_volume} \times \text{method_preference_share} \times \text{AOV} \times (1 - \text{fallback_rate})$

Signal flow

Direction	Connected agents
Sends to	Fraud Analyst, Cost Optimizer, Synthesis
Receives from	Fraud Analyst, KPI Monitor
Slack channels	#payments-optimisation (via synthesis)

Failure modes to avoid

- Estimating funnel metrics without product analytics data
- Conflating submit rate with success rate
- Reporting checkout conversion without specifying the denominator
- Assuming latency is only a PSP problem

Security Audit

Optimization & Analysis | Schedule: Weekly + on integration | ID: payments-security-audit

Runs security and compliance audits on payments infrastructure.

Core principle: Every finding must include a concrete exploit path — not a theoretical risk.
Zero-noise is the goal: if you can't explain exactly how the risk would be exploited, hold the finding.

What it does

- Audits PCI DSS scope and cardholder data environment (CDE) boundaries
- Applies OWASP API Security Top 10 to payment endpoints
- Verifies tokenization correctness — ensures raw PANs never appear where they shouldn't
- Checks PSP integration security: API key management, webhook signature validation, TLS, idempotency keys
- Identifies fraud control gaps that create exploitable attack surfaces

Key metrics & thresholds

- CVV stored anywhere = prohibited (PCI DSS 3.2)
- Unvalidated webhook endpoints = critical (attacker can fake payment confirmations)
- TLS 1.2+ minimum enforced on all PSP API calls
- Raw PAN in logs = automatic critical finding

Triage protocol

- Map all systems that store, process, or transmit cardholder data
- Verify card data entry happens in PSP-hosted field or is immediately tokenized
- Confirm servers never see raw PAN — only tokens
- Check CVV is never stored after authorization

Signal flow

Direction	Connected agents
Sends to	Synthesis, Regulatory Monitor
Receives from	Partner Health, Regulatory Monitor
Slack channels	#payments-alerts (critical/high findings only)

Failure modes to avoid

- Surfacing theoretical risks without concrete exploit paths
- Missing webhook signature validation — the most commonly missed control
- Ignoring test/sandbox credentials in production config

Reconciliation

Compliance & Relationships | Schedule: Daily / weekly / monthly | ID: payments-reconciliation

Reconciles PSP settlement reports against internal ledger, bank statements, and transaction records.

Core principle: Reconciliation failures are silent. A missing \$50K payout does not trigger an alert anywhere else in the payments stack. Only this agent finds it, and only if it runs proactively.

What it does

- Check 1: PSP settlement vs internal ledger — ghost transactions, orphan settlements, amount/status mismatches
- Check 2: PSP settlement vs bank statement — missing payouts, timing gaps, FX discrepancies
- Check 3: Fee reconciliation — effective fee rate vs contracted rate, flags billing above contract
- Runs on cadence: daily (PSP vs ledger), weekly (bank vs PSP), monthly (full fee recon for finance close)
- Zero tolerance for missing transactions; \$1 or 0.1% threshold for amount mismatches

Key metrics & thresholds

- Ghost transactions: in ledger, not in PSP settlement
- Orphan settlements: in PSP, not in ledger
- Payout timing: >2 business days outside contracted window = escalate
- Fee rate variance: >0.05% above contracted rate over 7 days = escalate
- Total unexplained variance: >\$500/day or >\$2,000/week = escalate

Signal flow

Direction	Connected agents
Sends to	Partner Health, Synthesis, Finance
Receives from	Partner Health, Cost Optimizer
Slack channels	#payments-alerts (critical discrepancies), #payments-briefing (daily summary)

Failure modes to avoid

- Only running reconciliation when something looks wrong (failures are silent)
- Ignoring fee rate drift because individual transactions are within tolerance
- Not classifying discrepancy type before investigating

Partner Health

Compliance & Relationships | Schedule: Weekly + before renewals | ID: payments-partner-health

Tracks PSP and payments vendor relationship health over time.

Core principle: Make sure the head of payments is never surprised in a vendor meeting and always knows the leverage position before a negotiation.

What it does

- Tracks PSPs: auth rate trends (30/60/90d), latency p99, uptime vs SLA, dispute quality, support responsiveness
- Tracks fraud vendors: model accuracy trend, rule update cadence, market coverage, API health
- Tracks BNPL providers: approval rates, settlement timing, dispute handling
- Monitors contract milestones: renewals (flag 90 days before), volume minimums, rate review windows
- Produces negotiation briefs: your leverage, their leverage, benchmark data, ranked ask list, walk-away position

Key metrics & thresholds

- SLA compliance tracked across: uptime, auth rate, latency, support response, dispute resolution
- Volume minimum on-track vs shortfall (shortfalls trigger penalties)
- Incidents per 90 days per PSP
- Performance trend: improving / stable / degrading

Signal flow

Direction	Connected agents
Sends to	Cost Optimizer, Synthesis, Security Audit
Receives from	Cost Optimizer, Incident Agent, Reconciliation
Slack channels	#payments-briefing (via synthesis)

Failure modes to avoid

- Accepting PSP self-reported auth rate numbers without verifying against your own data
- Missing a contract renewal window because milestones weren't tracked
- Entering a negotiation without calculating shiftable volume

Regulatory Monitor

Compliance & Relationships | Schedule: Weekly scans | ID: payments-regulatory-monitor

Monitors regulatory requirements, compliance deadlines, and regulatory change affecting payments.

Core principle: Track what the law and card schemes require of the business, not just the system.
Audience is head of payments AND legal/compliance.

What it does

- SCA/PSD2: tracks exemption categories, TRA thresholds, enforcement status by market, liability shift rules
- AML/KYC: SAR filing thresholds, CDD trigger events, transaction monitoring obligations, high-risk jurisdictions
- Card scheme mandates: 3DS version mandates, network token mandates, dispute rule changes, interchange changes
- Market licensing: payment institution license status, e-money requirements, data residency, consumer protection
- New market entry: produces regulatory checklist (licensing, local methods, AML, data residency, SCA, consumer protection, timeline)

Key metrics & thresholds

- Compliance posture: compliant / action_required / at_risk / unknown
- Days until next regulatory deadline
- Open regulatory examinations or inquiries
- Markets with data residency requirements

Signal flow

Direction	Connected agents
Sends to	Security Audit, Synthesis, Legal/Compliance
Receives from	Security Audit, Partner Health
Slack channels	#payments-briefing (via synthesis), #payments-compliance (direct alerts)

Failure modes to avoid

- Missing a card scheme mandate deadline (biannual rule book updates)
- Confusing regulatory compliance with technical security (different agents)
- Providing market entry timelines without accounting for licensing lead times

Synthesis Agent

Synthesis Layer | Schedule: Daily 08:00 + weekly Monday | ID: payments-synthesis

Reads all agent outputs and produces the daily briefing and weekly executive summary.

Core principle: *The difference between a good briefing and a useless one is whether it replaces 30 minutes of investigation or just documents that something happened. Max 5 findings per day — if you have 8, you haven't prioritized.*

What it does

- Reads structured JSON from all 9 specialist agents
- Scans for cross-agent correlations before treating outputs independently
- Scores findings: $\text{impact_usd_per_day} \times \text{urgency_multiplier} \times \text{confidence_multiplier}$
- Resolves agent conflicts by flagging them explicitly, never picking sides
- Produces daily briefing (max 5 findings) and weekly Monday summary (Win, Open issue, Watch, Priority)

Key metrics & thresholds

- Priority score = $\text{impact_usd} \times \text{urgency}$ (immediate=3, this_week=2, monitor=1) $\times$ confidence (high=1.0, med=0.7, low=0.4)
- Daily briefing: max 5 findings, each with what/why/cause/action/owner
- Weekly summary: exactly 4 sections for leadership

Signal flow

Direction	Connected agents
Sends to	Head of Payments (daily), VP/Leadership (weekly), All agent owners
Receives from	All 9 specialist agents
Slack channels	#payments-briefing (daily), #payments-leadership (weekly Monday)

Failure modes to avoid

- Forwarding 8 findings instead of prioritizing 5
- Treating correlated signals as separate findings (auth drop + fraud tightening = one story)
- Declaring 'healthy' without checking all Tier 1 metrics

3. Cross-Agent Correlation Patterns

The Synthesis Agent scans for these patterns before treating each agent's output independently. When a pattern matches, the correlated findings are merged into a single narrative. The head of payments should not have to connect the dots themselves.

Signal pattern	What it means
Auth rate down + fraud rate down + FP up	Fraud model tightened too aggressively — one problem, not three
Auth rate drop on PSP A only + PSP A status degraded	PSP incident — route around it
Success rate drop + recent deploy	Engineering incident — not payments-specific
Checkout abandonment up + 3DS challenge rate up	3DS overtriggering is killing conversion
Cost per transaction up + method mix shifting to cards	Mix shift problem, not fee negotiation
False positives up in one market + no fraud increase	Model drift in that market — recalibrate
Reconciliation variance up + PSP settlement delays	PSP payout issue — escalate to partner health
Partner health degrading + cost optimizer flags same PSP	Double signal — relationship and routing need attention
Regulatory deadline <30 days + incomplete implementation	Sequencing risk — may block launch

When agents contradict each other (e.g., KPI monitor says auth rate is healthy but fraud analyst flags abnormal decline patterns), the Synthesis Agent does not pick one. It flags the conflict explicitly, describes what each agent found and why they differ, and recommends the next step to resolve it — usually looking at one more data slice.

4. Use Case Scenarios

These scenarios demonstrate how agents collaborate on real problems. Each scenario shows the signal chain from detection through synthesis.

Scenario 1: PSP Outage

1	KPI Monitor	Detects auth rate drop of 2.3% on Adyen EU, sustained 12 minutes. Segments by PSP — isolated to one provider.
2	Incident Agent	Runs triage: Adyen status page confirms degradation. No recent deploys. Blast radius narrow (EU cards only). Downgrades to P2. Recommends routing shift to Stripe.
3	Cost Optimizer	Validates Stripe has capacity. Stripe auth rate is 0.8% higher on this segment even normally. Flags permanent routing opportunity: \$47K/month.
4	Partner Health	Logs incident against Adyen SLA record. 3rd P2+ incident in 90 days — SLA breach approaching. Adds to negotiation brief.
5	Synthesis	Merges four signals into one finding: 'Adyen EU degradation — routed around, \$47K/mo permanent opportunity, SLA breach approaching.' Rank 1 in daily briefing.

Scenario 2: Fraud Model Drift

1	Fraud Analyst	False positive rate rising 0.7% in LATAM with no fraud increase. Score distributions shifting. Model drift confirmed. ~340 good customers blocked/day.
2	KPI Monitor	Confirms auth rate in LATAM dropped 0.4%. Decline type: fraud blocks, not issuer declines.
3	Checkout Optimizer	3DS challenge rate spiked to 12% in LATAM (threshold: 8%). Submit-to-complete ratio dropped. Conversion impact: 2.1% effective loss.
4	Synthesis	One narrative: 'Fraud model drift in LATAM blocking 340 good customers/day, killing 2.1% conversion, overtriggering 3DS. One fix: recalibrate LATAM model.'

Scenario 3: New Market Launch (Brazil)

1	Regulatory Monitor	Market entry checklist: PIX mandate, BACEN licensing, data residency, local AML thresholds. Estimated 4-month timeline.
2	Checkout Optimizer	PIX accounts for ~30% of online payments in Brazil. Without it, massive conversion gap. Revenue impact: \$280K/month at projected volume.
3	Cost Optimizer	Evaluates PSP options for local acquiring. Recommends Adyen (best auth rates), Stripe as backup. Network token availability assessed.
4	Partner Health	Adyen contract covers Brazil but volume minimum needs renegotiation. 60-day lead time for rate review window.

5	Security Audit	Pre-launch review: PIX integration security, new webhook endpoints, data residency compliance for transaction logs.
6	Synthesis	Consolidates into launch readiness brief for leadership: regulatory timeline, revenue opportunity, PSP recommendation, security gaps, contract actions.

Scenario 4: Daily Briefing Assembly

1	All 9 Agents	Each runs scheduled analysis. Produces structured JSON: KPI snapshot, fraud metrics, cost opportunities, recon status, partner health, regulatory updates, checkout funnel, security findings, incident log.
2	Synthesis	Reads all outputs. Scans for cross-agent correlations first. Scores each finding: dollar impact x urgency x confidence.
3	Synthesis	Selects top 5 findings max. Each with: what changed, why it matters, likely cause, specific action, owner. Carry-overs from yesterday included.
4	Synthesis	Posts to #payments-briefing at 08:00. Head of payments reads 5 findings and knows where to spend their next hour.

5. Slack Channel Map

Channel	Purpose	Who posts	When
#payments-incidents	P0 critical outages with @here	Incident Agent	P0 only — success rate <95% sustained 5+ min
#payments-alerts	P1-P2 alerts, security findings, fraud spikes, Fraud, Security, P1	Recon	Immediately; P2 during business hours
#payments-briefing	Daily synthesized briefing	Synthesis Agent	Daily at 08:00
#payments-leadership	Weekly executive summary	Synthesis Agent	Monday 08:00
#payments-optimisation	Cost and checkout opportunities	Cost Optimizer, Checkout Optimizer	When opportunity >\$10K/mo identified
#payments-compliance	Regulatory alerts	Regulatory Monitor	When deadline <30 days or posture changes

6. Appendix: Output JSON Schemas

Every agent produces structured JSON following a common contract. The key fields that enable cross-agent synthesis are: severity, confidence, hypothesis, impact estimate, and recommended action. Below is the common output contract that all agents follow.

Field	Type	Description
agent	string	Agent identifier (e.g., 'payments-kpi-monitor')
timestamp	ISO 8601	When the analysis was run
run_type	enum	scheduled_hourly on_demand triggered incident_triggered
findings[].severity	enum	P0 P1 P2 P3 info opportunity
findings[].confidence	enum	high medium low
findings[].hypothesis	string	One sentence — what likely caused this
findings[].impact_estimate	USD	Dollar amount per hour (incidents) or per month (opportunities)
findings[].recommended_action	string	Specific, actionable next step
findings[].affected_segment	string	PSP / market / method / BIN range
slack_notification.should_notify	boolean	Whether to send a Slack message
slack_notification.channel	string	Target Slack channel
slack_notification.message	string	Ready-to-send formatted message

Agent-specific schemas extend this common contract with domain fields. For example, the Fraud Analyst adds `calibration_signal`, `fraud_rate_bps`, `false_positive_rate_pct`, and `model_health`. The Reconciliation Agent adds `discrepancies` array with type classification, variance amounts, and fee reconciliation summary. See individual agent skill files for complete schemas.

Synthesis Priority Formula

priority_score = impact_usd_per_day x urgency_multiplier x confidence_multiplier

Urgency: immediate = 3, this_week = 2, monitor = 1

Confidence: high = 1.0, medium = 0.7, low = 0.4

Findings are surfaced in descending priority order. The head of payments should read the first finding and immediately know where to spend their next hour.